

Before 2055, Which Other Countries Might Become Developed Countries?

Zhihu · 2026-09-13

In the article I published yesterday ("The Prospects of Reformism") I discussed the prospects of reformism at present and over the coming thirty years. A basic assumption of that analysis is that in the next 30 years, apart from China, no other heavyweight country or group of countries (with a combined population above 500 million) will for the time being be able to upgrade into the ranks of the developed countries — that is, to enter the centre of the world-system. Some will regard this assumption as plain common sense that needs no discussion, since many even hold that China has already welded shut the door of industrialisation for other countries, let alone for their upgrading to developed status. Others may be sceptical of the assumption — after all, if China can do a thing, why can't other countries? In this article we shall dissect the question in detail and see which countries, apart from China, have a chance of entering the centre of the world-system in the next 30 years.

In the era of the globalisation of production, a developed country is developed not only because of its own manufacturing capacity, but even more because it has enough global leading enterprises to provide it with enough jobs in production services, research and development and high-end manufacturing, sustaining a per-capita GDP far above the world average.

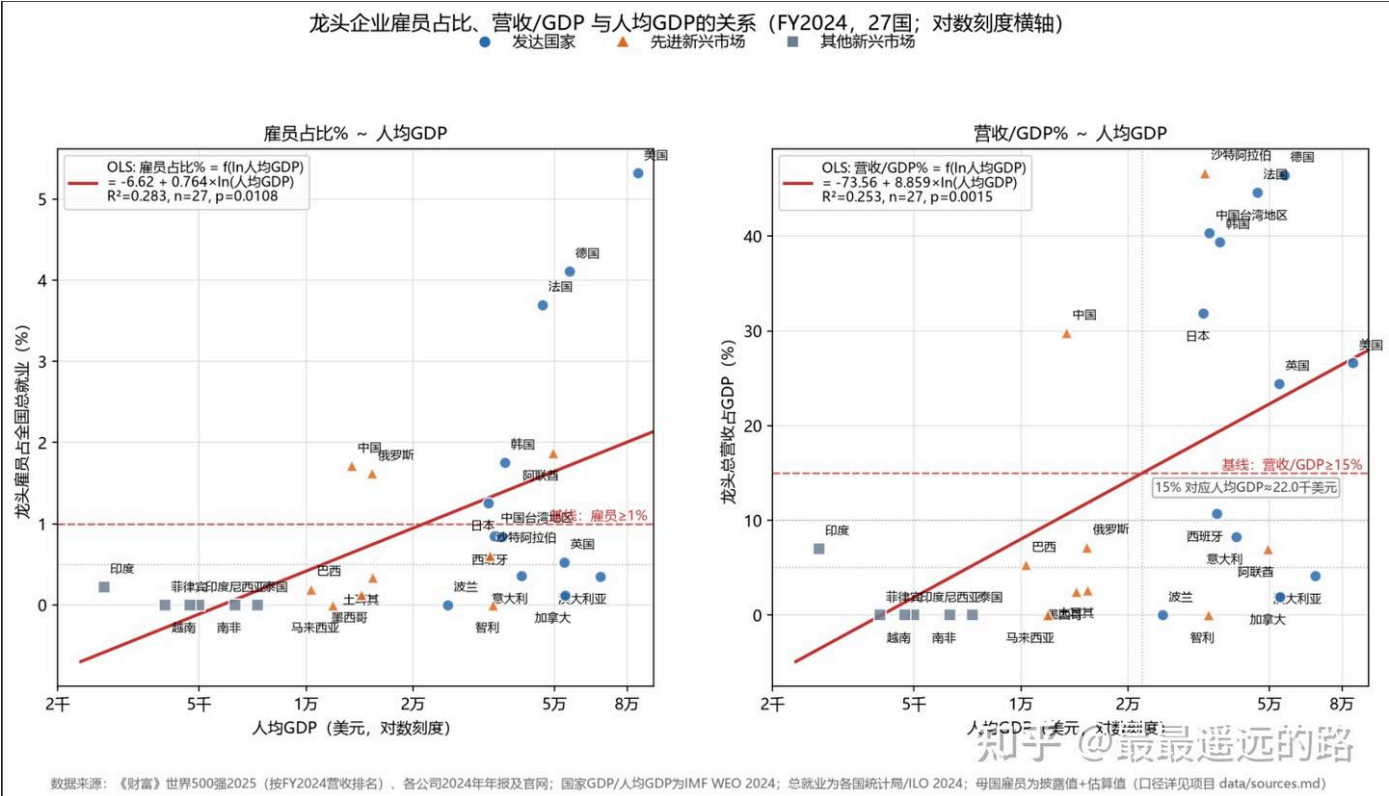
Below is the situation of the leading enterprises (the global TOP10) that entered the world's top ten by revenue in 31 industries in 2024. Our analysis proceeds from these data.

各行业·各国头部企业数（全球前10）

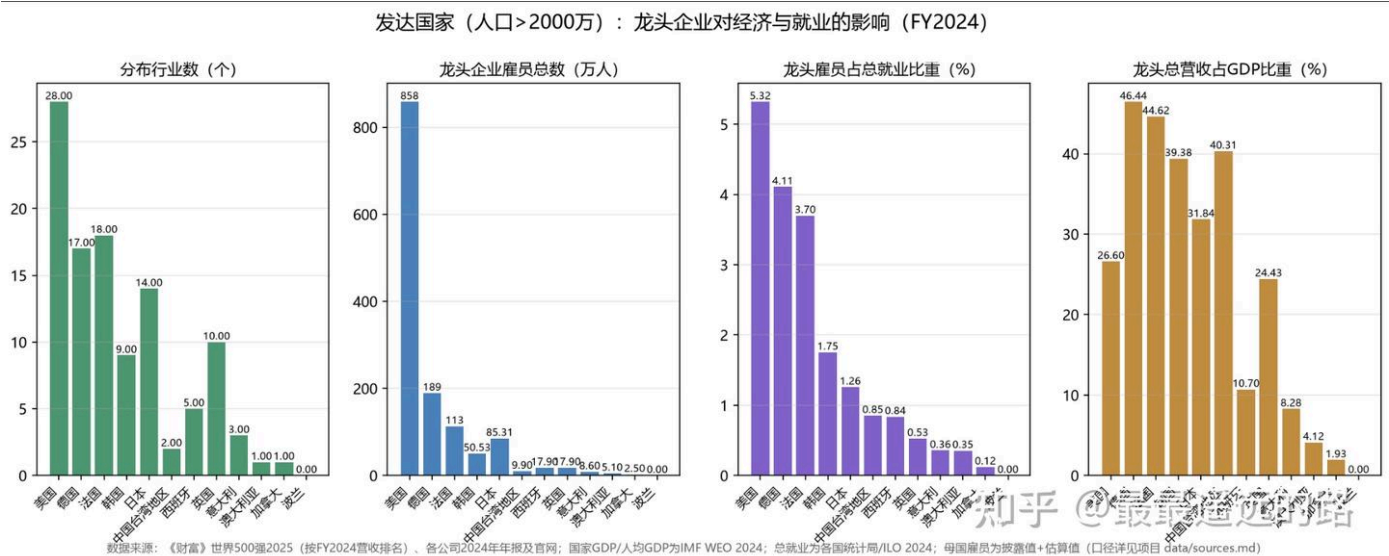
行业	各国企业数（该行业全球前10内）
汽车整车	德国（3）、日本（2）、美国（2）、荷兰（1）、韩国（1）、中国（1）
汽车零部件与动力电池	德国（3）、日本（3）、法国（2）、中国（1）、加拿大（1）、韩国（1）
造船	韩国（4）、中国（3）、美国（1）、意大利（1）、法国（1）
航空航天军工客机	美国（6）、法国（2）、英国（2）
半导体	美国（6）、中国台湾地区（2）、韩国（2）
半导体设备	美国（4）、日本（3）、荷兰（2）、中国（1）
消费电子与电子制造	美国（3）、韩国（2）、日本（2）、中国（2）、中国台湾地区（1）
制药	美国（5）、瑞士（2）、英国（1）、法国（1）、丹麦（1）
化工	德国（2）、中国（2）、美国（1）、荷兰（1）、沙特阿拉伯（1）、英国（1）、法国（1）、日本（1）
钢铁	中国（5）、日本（2）、卢森堡（1）、韩国（1）、德国（1）
石油天然气	中国（2）、美国（2）、英国（2）、沙特阿拉伯（1）、法国（1）、印度（1）、俄罗斯（1）
矿业	澳大利亚（2）、英国（2）、中国（2）、美国（2）、瑞士（1）、巴西（1）
重型机械(工程机械+农机)	美国（3）、日本（2）、英国（2）、中国（2）、德国（1）
电气与能源装备	日本（3）、美国（3）、德国（2）、法国（1）、瑞士（1）
轨道交通装备	德国（2）、中国（1）、法国（1）、美国（1）、日本（1）、西班牙（1）、瑞士（1）、俄罗斯（1）、韩国（1）
电信设备	中国（4）、美国（4）、瑞典（1）、芬兰（1）
互联网平台与电商	中国（6）、美国（4）
软件与IT服务	美国（6）、印度（2）、爱尔兰（1）、德国（1）、法国（1）
银行	美国（4）、中国（4）、日本（1）、英国（1）
保险	美国（4）、中国（3）、德国（1）、法国（1）、印度（1）、意大利（1）
零售	美国（5）、德国（3）、法国（1）、荷兰（1）
食品饮料	美国（5）、瑞士（1）、巴西（1）、比利时（1）、荷兰（1）、法国（1）
家电	中国（4）、韩国（2）、日本（1）、德国（1）、美国（1）、瑞典（1）、土耳其（1）
奢侈品与美妆	法国（5）、美国（2）、英国（1）、德国（1）、瑞士（1）
医疗设备	美国（6）、爱尔兰（1）、法国（1）、德国（1）、荷兰（1）
服装与运动用品	美国（4）、德国（2）、西班牙（1）、瑞典（1）、日本（1）、中国（1）
工程建设	中国（7）、法国（2）、西班牙（1）
航空运输	美国（4）、中国（2）、德国（1）、阿联酋（1）、英国（1）、法国（1）、土耳其（1）
电信运营	中国（3）、美国（2）、德国（1）、日本（1）、墨西哥（1）、西班牙（1）、法国（1）
电力与公用事业	中国（2）、法国（2）、意大利（1）、德国（1）、韩国（1）、西班牙（1）、日本（1）、美国（1）
国防军工	中国（5）、美国（4）、俄罗斯（1）、英国（1）

The figure below shows the relationship between per-capita GDP and, on the one hand, the share of leading-enterprise employees in total employment and, on the other, their revenue as a share of GDP, for the world's major developed countries and the more advanced developing countries. It can be seen that in developed countries both the share of leading-enterprise employees in total employment and revenue as a share of GDP are on the whole higher than in the emerging market countries. It can also be seen that China's two indicators are already higher than those of developed countries such as Italy, Australia, Canada and Poland, though still lower than those of the other East Asian economies and of the core developed economies — the US, France, Germany and Britain. A regression analysis of the data for emerging developing countries and developed countries allows us to establish simply that the baseline supporting developed-country status is: the share of leading-enterprise employees in total employment above 1%, and revenue as a share of GDP above 15%. In fact, the generally recognised developed countries also meet this indicator; even where there are differences, they are not great. This accords with the present situation: Poland is not yet recognised as a developed

country, while Canada and Australia have in recent years been regarded as developed countries in name only.

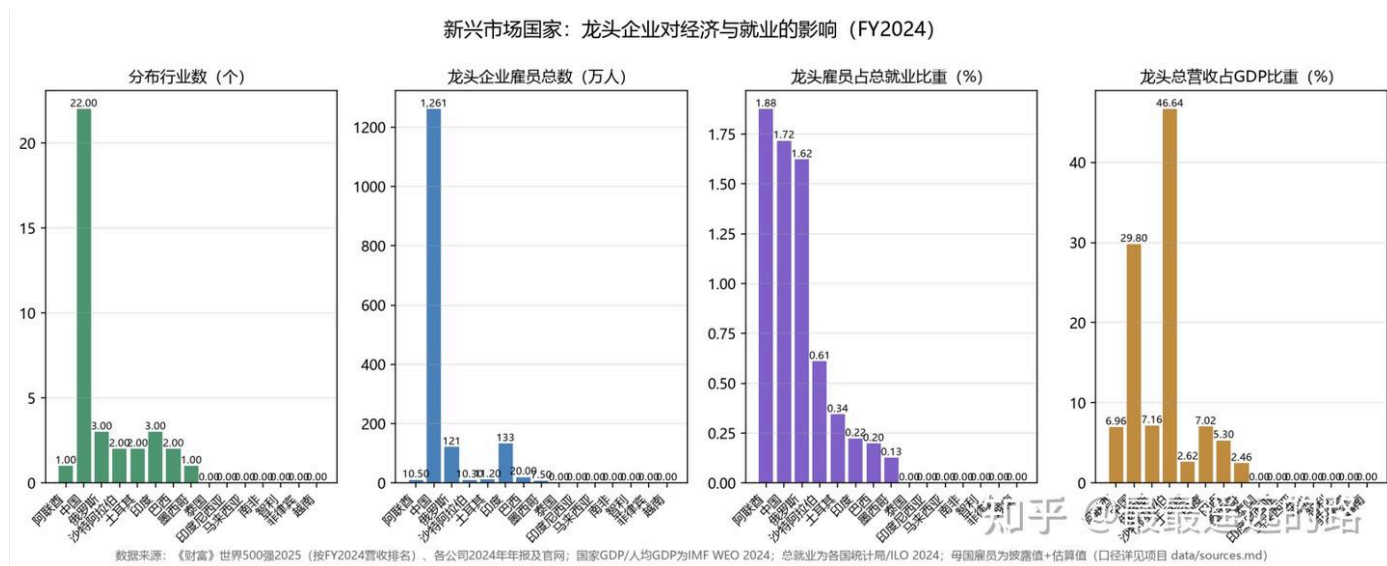


As the figure below shows, among the developed countries, those with a larger number of industries covered by their leading enterprises and higher shares of leading-enterprise employees and revenue in GDP are generally the more developed ones. The lower these indicators fall, the more a country is generally acknowledged to be insufficiently developed.



Among the emerging economies, only China and the UAE meet the employment-share indicator, while as for revenue as a share of GDP, China has reached the level of some core developed countries

and Saudi Arabia has almost reached the American level.



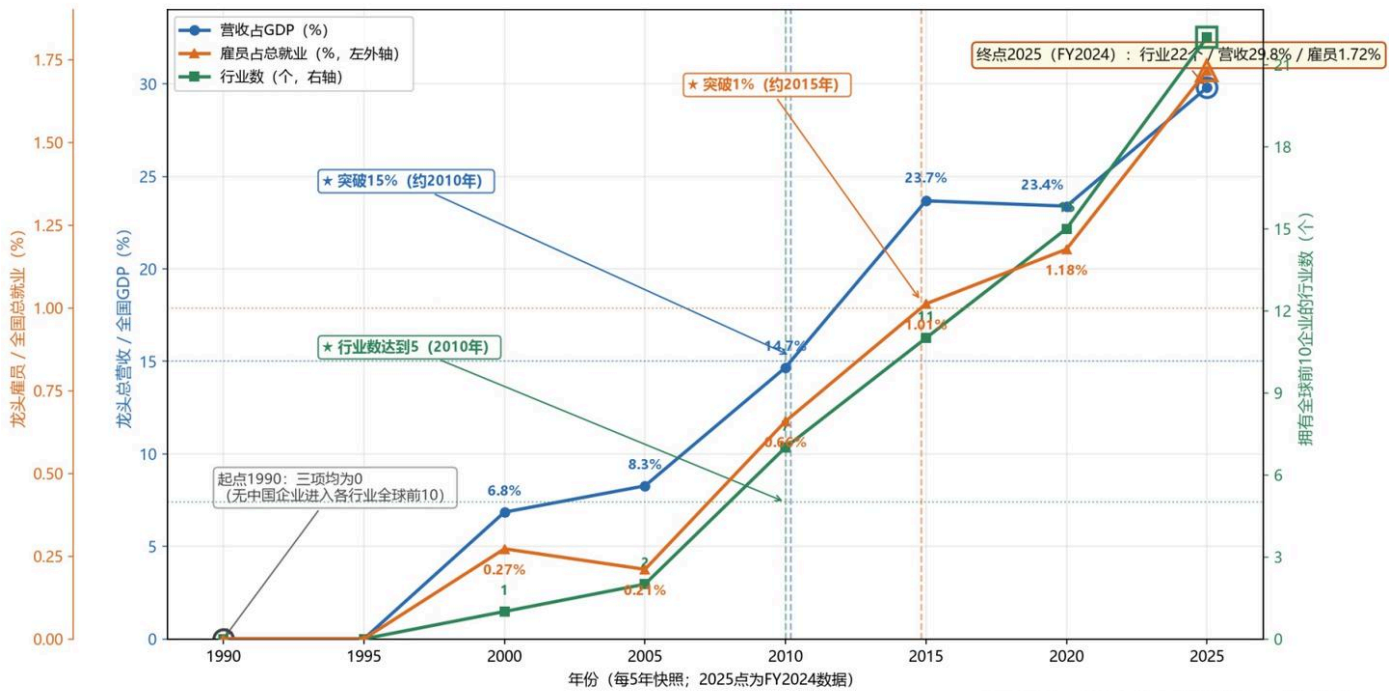
By this standard, which countries might upgrade to developed-country status? On the present picture, the candidates are: China, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Russia, Turkey, India, Mexico and Brazil. Other countries have no global leading enterprises as yet, and in the next 30 years the likelihood of their cultivating enterprises whose total revenue exceeds 10% of GDP is extremely low, so they need hardly be considered.

China first. The revenue of China's leading enterprises as a share of GDP has reached the level of Britain, America and Japan, and their employment share has also reached the level of Britain and Japan. China therefore already possesses the hard strength to become a developed country: in the next 10 years it can complete the relocation of its low- and mid-end industries and enlarge its high-end industries, and through adjustments to nominal GDP via the exchange rate and inflation it will become a developed country.

Other countries start from a lower base, and it is hard to predict how far they will develop in the next 30 years; let us look first at China's development as a reference. As the figure below shows, it took China about 15 years (up to 2015) to go from the appearance of its first leading enterprise to the baseline level. This is why the developed countries began to feel obvious competitive pressure from China only after 2015. The figure also shows that China, having begun its ultra-rapid development in 1990, needed 25 years to reach the standard; countries whose other indicators are essentially zero would need to grow at an average annual GDP rate of at least 8%–9% for 25 years to reach the standard, which is all but impossible.

基线标准 (两项) : 雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ (行业数为参考项) → 2025(FY2024): 雇员1.72%√ · 营收29.8%√

中国龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业比重 (1990–2025)



数据来源: 历年《财富》世界500强榜单 (Fortune Global 500 1996–2025) 及各公司年报, 5年快照估算; 国家GDP为World Bank/IMF, 总就业为NBS/ILO; 含银行的营收为报表口径; 详细方法与行业名单见 data/china_trend.csv

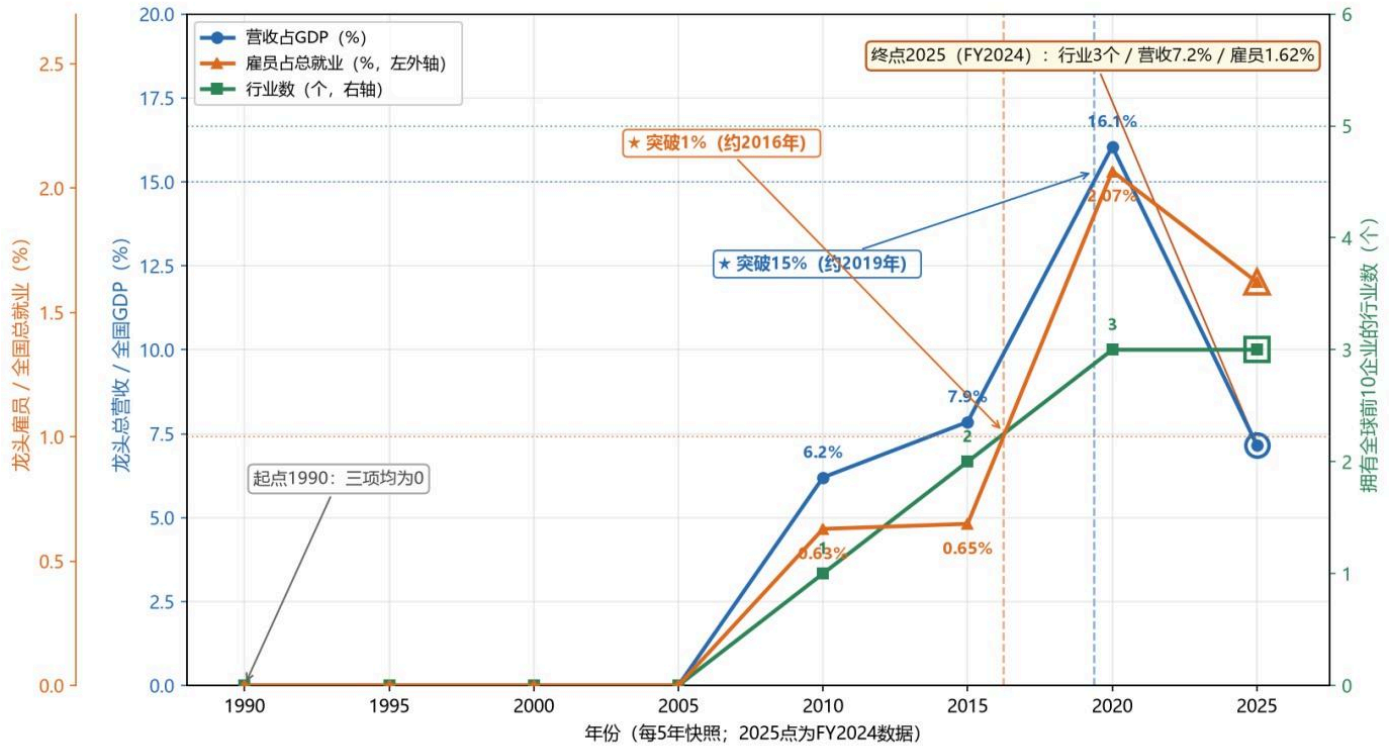
知乎 @最最遥远的路

Let us now look in turn at each of the other candidate countries.

The figure below shows Russia's situation. As the figure shows, Russia reached the baseline in 2019 and acquired the hard-strength foundation for becoming a developed country. But after the Russia–Ukraine war the situation deteriorated abruptly and the future is unclear. If Russia can repair its relations with the West, have the sanctions lifted and rely on the industrial base it inherited from the Soviet Union (nuclear power, gas turbines, military industry, metallurgy and so on), it is possible that it will develop into an entry-level developed country within the next 30 years.

基线标准 (两项) : 雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ (行业数为参考项) → 2025(FY2024): 雇员1.62%√ · 营收7.2%×

俄罗斯：龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业 (1990–2025)



数据来源：历年《财富》世界500强、各公司年报（5年快照估算）；GDP为World Bank/IMF；总就业为ILO/各国统计局。详细方法见附录。

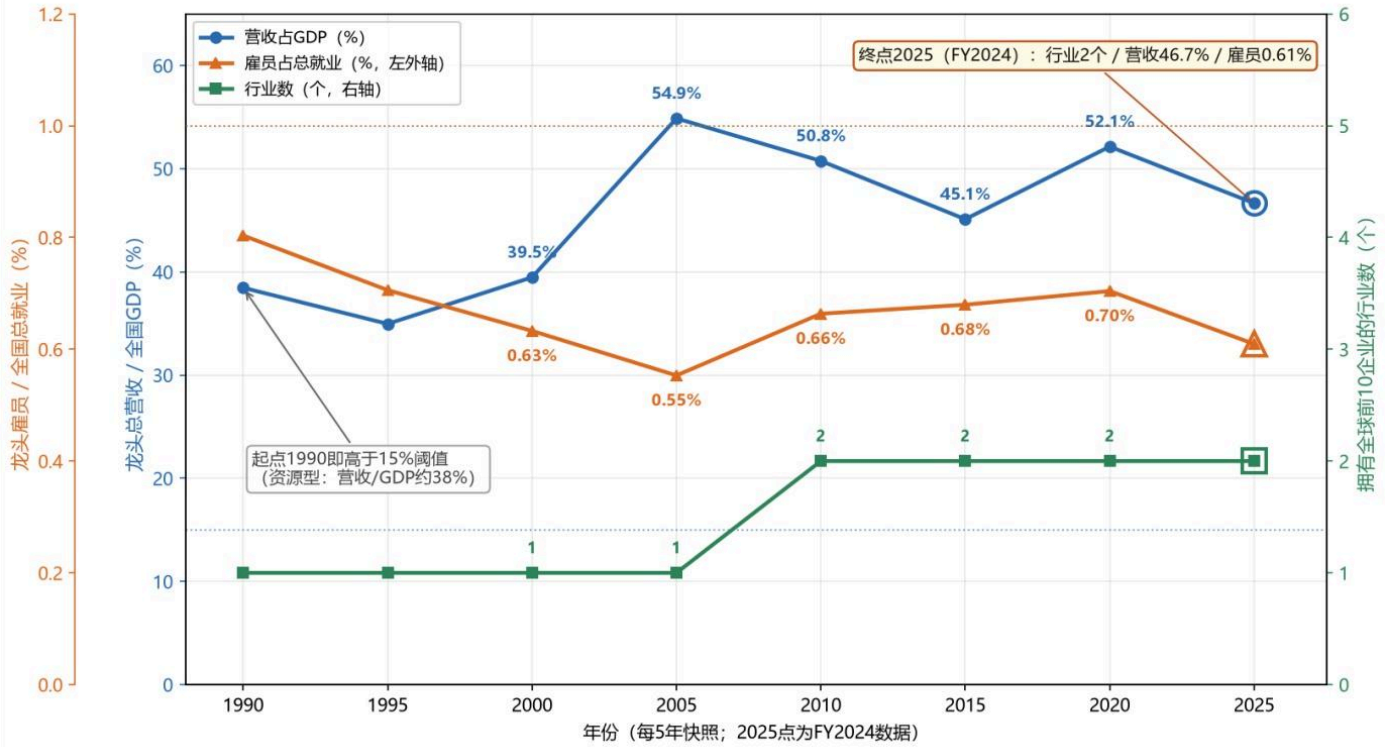
注：俄气为国有；油气营收含出口，受卢布汇率与油价周期影响大

知乎 @最遥远的路

Now Saudi Arabia and the UAE, the two energy countries. Since 2010 the momentum of leading-enterprise development in both countries has stalled or declined, with no sign of rising. To date Saudi Arabia's employment share has not reached the standard, while the UAE's revenue indicator has not. That is to say, apart from energy and chemical enterprises, other industries in these two resource countries, even when they develop, can only reach the level of a semi-peripheral industrial country.

基线标准（两项）：雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ （行业数为参考项） → 2025(FY2024)：雇员0.61% × 营收46.7%√

沙特阿拉伯：龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业（1990–2025）

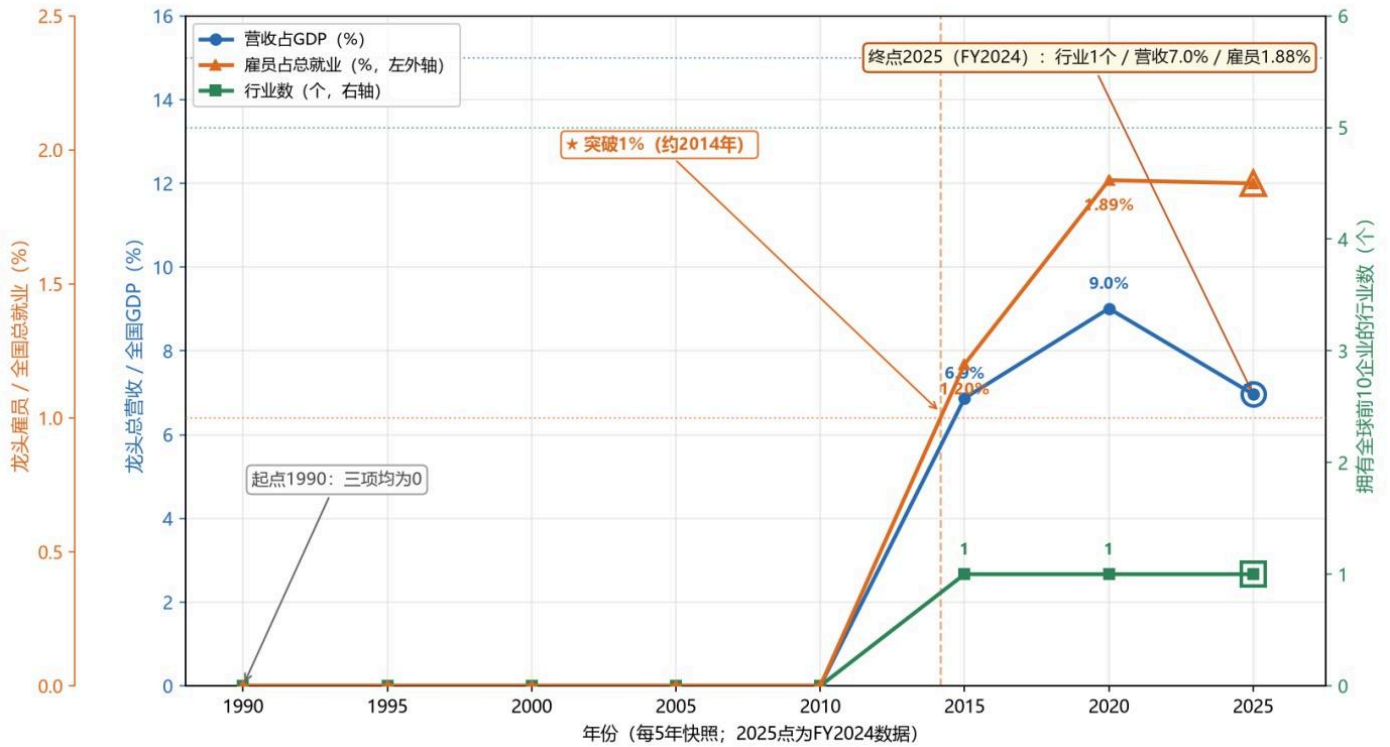


数据来源：历年《财富》世界500强、各公司年报（5年快照估算）；GDP为World Bank/IMF；总就业为ILO/各国统计局。详细方法见附录。知乎 @最遥远的路

注：沙特阿美为国有未上市至2019年，早期营收为估算；资源型：营收占比极高但就业吸纳低

基准标准 (两项) : 雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ (行业数为参考项) → 2025(FY2024): 雇员1.88% · 营收7.0% ×

阿联酋: 龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业 (1990–2025)

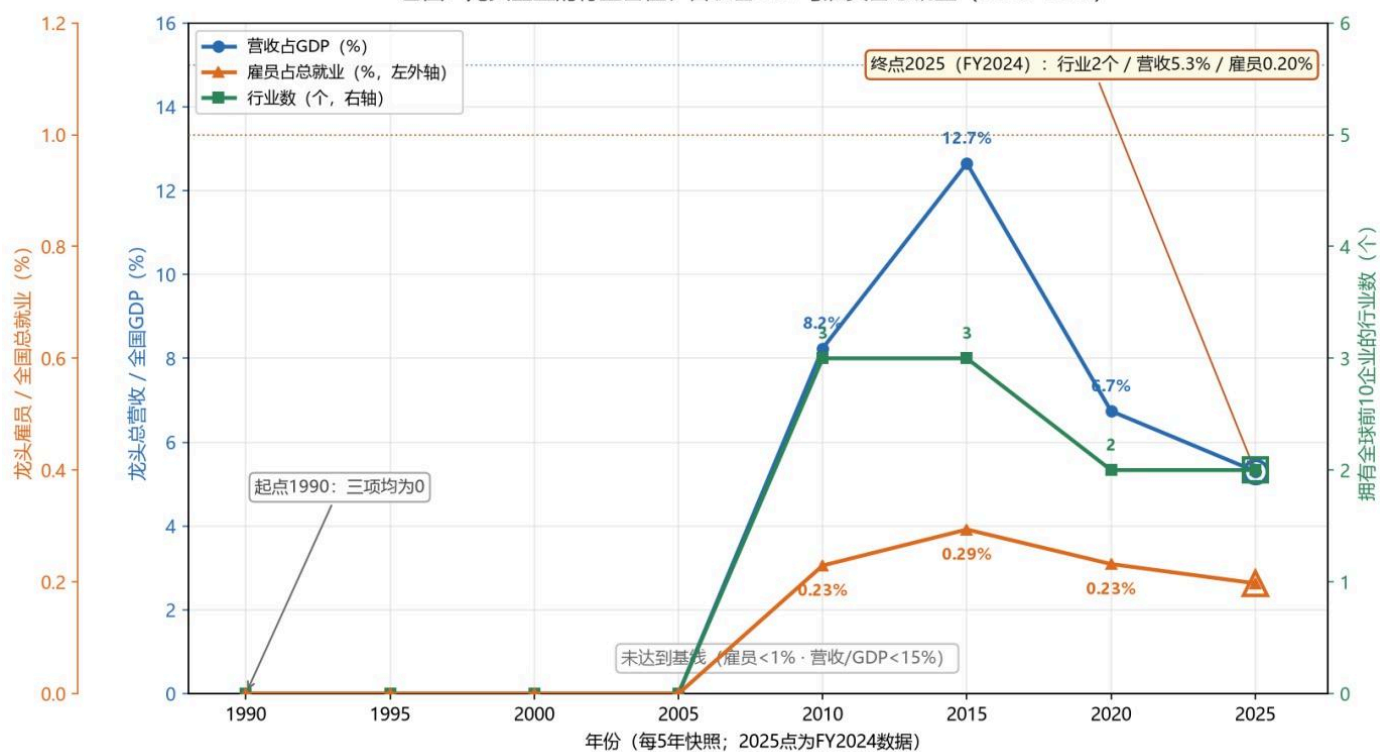


数据来源: 历年《财富》世界500强、各公司年报 (5年快照估算); GDP为World Bank/IMF; 总就业为ILO/各国统计局。详细方法与数据参见[知乎@最遥远的路](#)。
注: 仅阿联酋航空1家; 雇员占比高源于全国总就业仅约560万 (大量外籍劳工)

The figure below shows Brazil and Mexico. These two countries are typical of those caught in the middle-income trap; since 2010 no new large enterprises have grown up in either, and though more development may come in the future, the likelihood of reaching the baseline is low, unless a major political change occurs at home.

基线标准 (两项) : 雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ (行业数为参考项) → 2025(FY2024): 雇员0.20% × 营收5.3% ×

巴西: 龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业 (1990–2025)

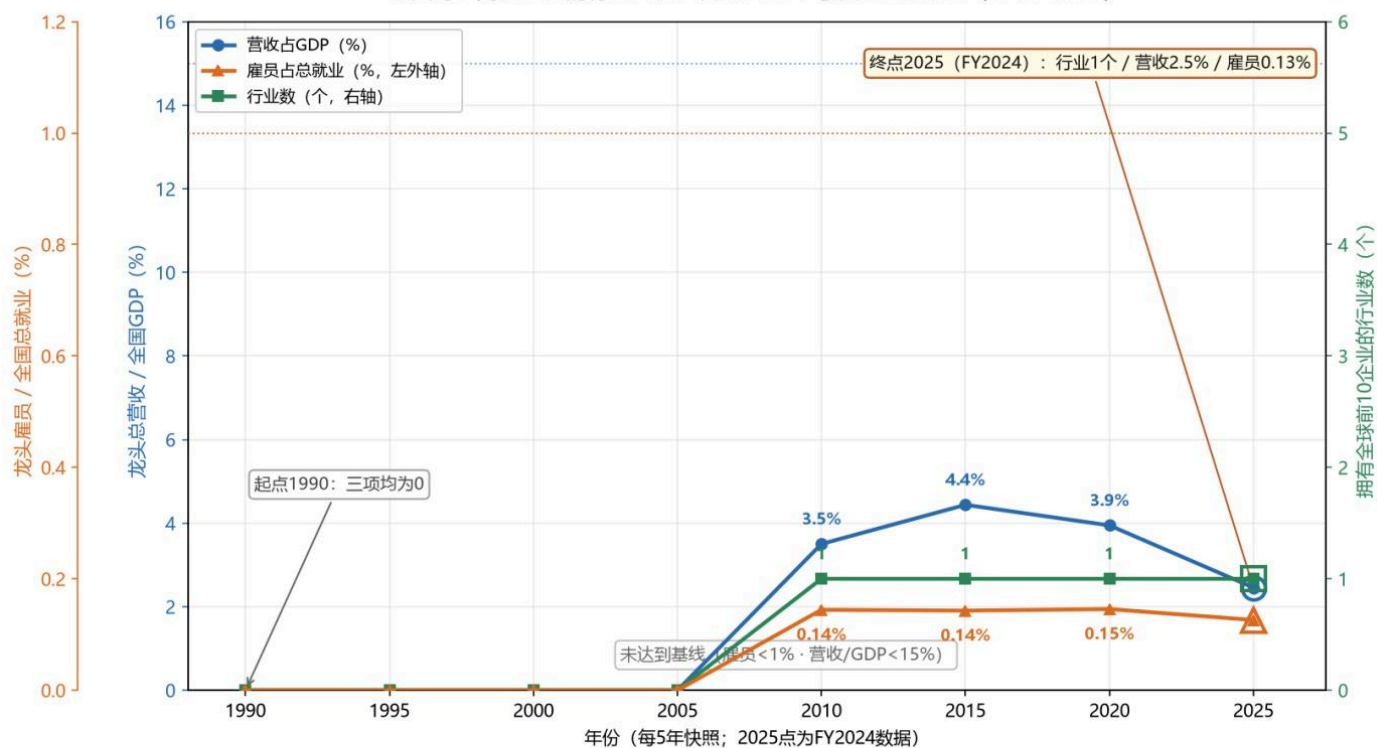


数据来源: 历年《财富》世界500强、各公司年报 (5年快照估算); GDP为World Bank/IMF; 总就业为ILO/各国统计局。详细方法与数据源见附录。

注: 巴西石油+淡水河谷; 两大国企持续裁员 (巴西石油雇员8.1万→4.4万); 2015年营收占比9.9%逼近10%阈值

基线标准 (两项) : 雇员占总就业 $\geq 1\%$ · 营收占GDP $\geq 15\%$ (行业数为参考项) → 2025(FY2024): 雇员0.13% × 营收2.5% ×

墨西哥：龙头企业的行业占位、营收占GDP与雇员占总就业 (1990–2025)

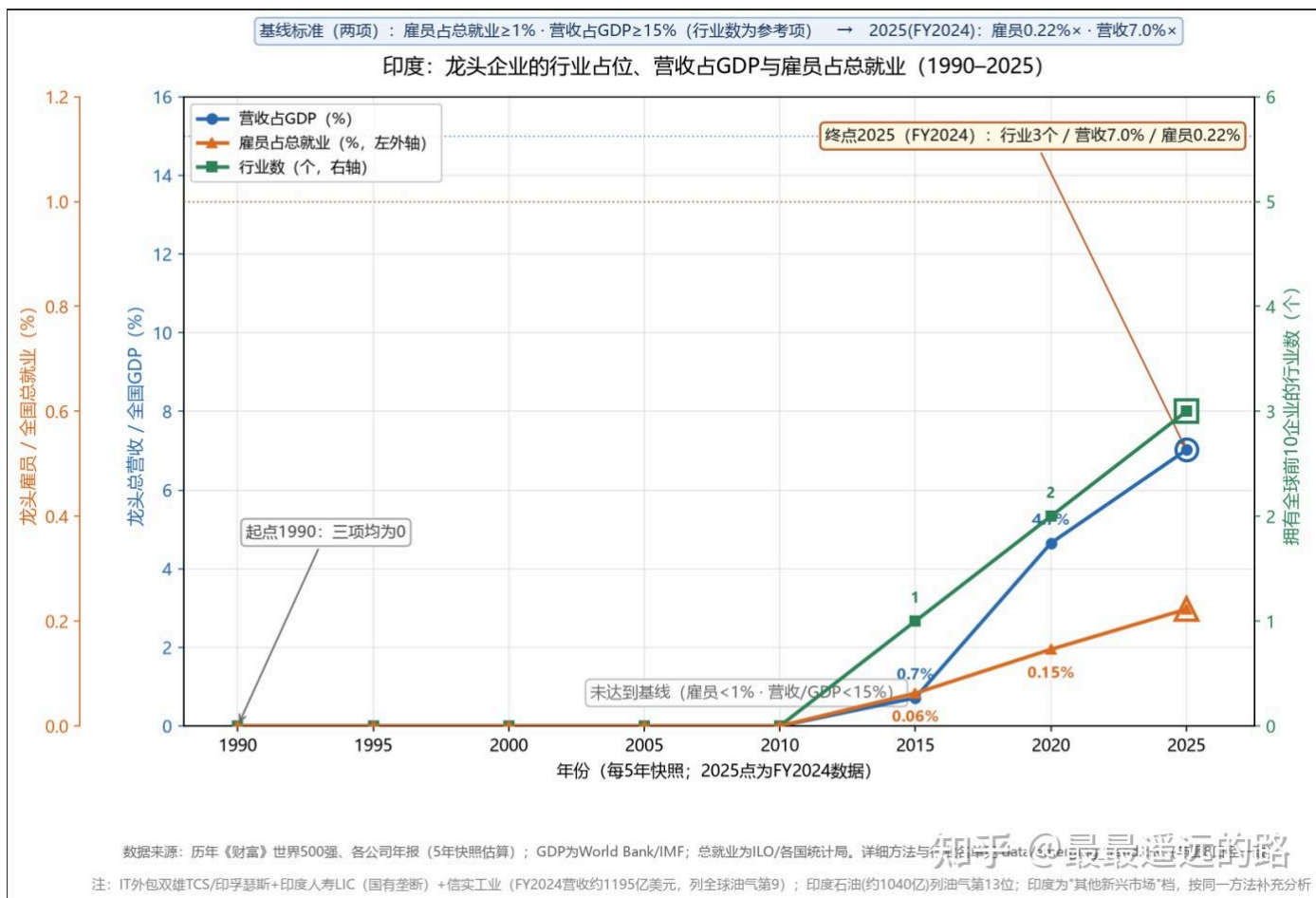


数据来源: 历年《财富》世界500强、各公司年报 (5年快照估算); GDP为World Bank/IMF; 总就业为ILO/各国统计局。详细方法与行业定义见附录。

注: 仅美洲电信1家 (电信运营); 墨西哥本土雇员约7.5万, 其余在拉美各国。

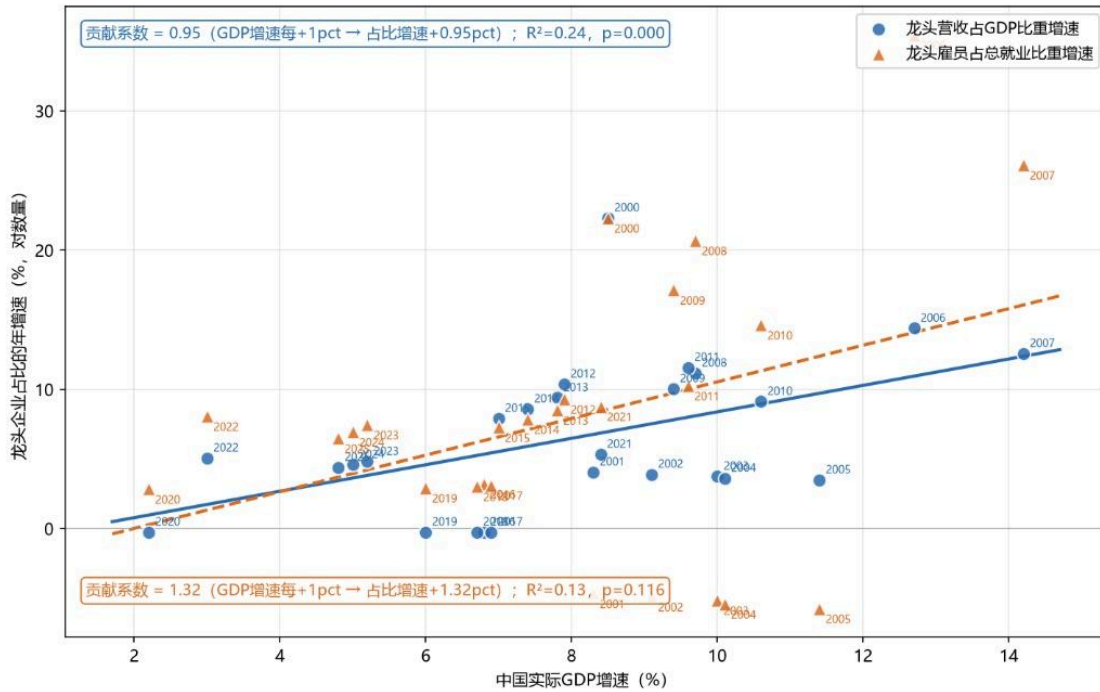
知乎 @最遥远的路

Turkey's rise since 2020 has been conspicuous. Besides the two industries in which it has already entered the top ten, Turkey is pressing forward in military industry and aerospace, and its probability of upgrading to developed-country status in the future is even higher than Russia's.



As the figure below shows, on the basis of China's data, the GDP growth rate can explain 95% of the growth rate of the leading-enterprise share; the two are highly correlated.

中国GDP增速与龙头企业占比增速的线性关系（2000–2025）

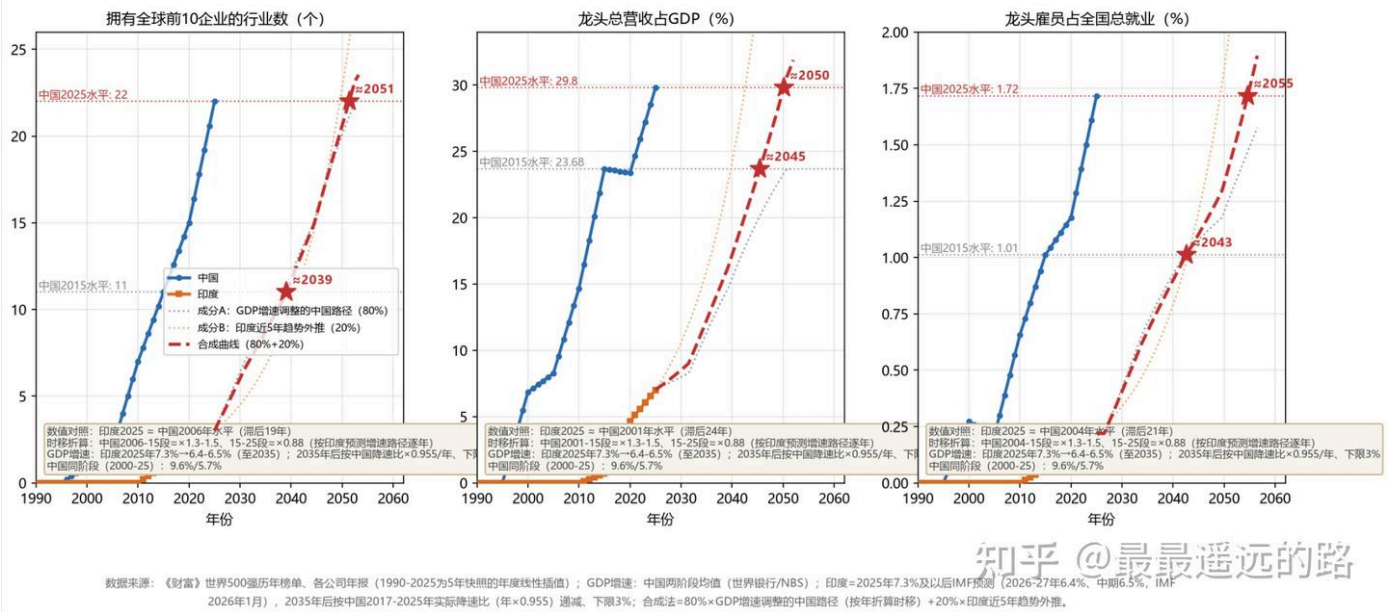


知乎 @最最遥远的路

数据来源：GDP实际增速=世界银行/NBS（2025年=IMF预测4.8%）；龙头占比=《财富》世界500强历年榜单+企业年报（china_trend.csv的5年快照→年度插值，占比年增速由其计算，属平滑估计）；回归含HC1稳健标准误与t检验

Indian enterprises are more globalised than Chinese ones at the same stage, so, using a simple method — 80% according to the difference in GDP growth rates at the same stage, 20% by smoothing the historical course of the curve — I have drawn the forecast figure below. The GDP growth rates are taken from the pattern of China's historical GDP slowdown and used to adjust the projected values for India. It can be seen that India will not reach China's 2015 level until 2040 to 2045, and China's 2025 level only in the 2050s. Since the market space available when India rises is smaller and the resistance greater, this timeline is very likely to be stretched further. Still, by 2055 India can indeed develop to a level between China's 2015 and 2025 levels, and will possess the strength to make an assault on the centre of the world-system.

中国 vs 印度：龙头指标演进与印度追赶时间预测（合成法：80%GDP增速调整路径 + 20%历史趋势）



By 2055, therefore, the world's developed countries will fall into the following categories:

The old developed countries: Europe, America, Britain, Japan, Korea, Australia, Canada, New Zealand and so on. By 2055 their total population will be about 1.1 billion.

The newly developed countries: China (very high probability), Turkey (high probability), Russia (medium probability). By 2055 their total population will be about 1.4 billion.

Countries making a large-scale assault on the centre of the system: India (very high probability). By 2055 its population will be about 1.5 billion.

The remaining countries have a total population of about 5 billion; but of these 5 billion, only sub-Saharan Africa has not yet completed industrialisation. Other newly industrialising regions — the Middle East and North Africa, and Southeast Asia — may also develop a number of leading enterprises in some of their more advanced countries, such as Vietnam, Indonesia, the UAE and Saudi Arabia (the four together holding 500 million people), though these will not be enough to support their own countries' becoming developed; they will nonetheless enter into competition with India. And in sub-Saharan Africa the level of industrialisation will reach that of China between 2000 and 2005, with a total population of about 2 billion.

By 2055, then, the 2.5 billion people of the developed countries, the 1.4 billion of India, and the 500 million of the other semi-peripheral powers will all be contending for the emerging market of sub-Saharan Africa's 2 billion people. By comparison, the present contest — 1.6 billion people (China, Russia and Turkey) and another 1.1 billion (the developed countries) scrambling together for an incremental market of nearly 5 billion others — amounts to a very mild environment indeed. Even so,

wars have been breaking out one after another; one can imagine what breadth and intensity war will reach thirty years from now.

This article was originally published on Zhihu (in Chinese): <https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2082412798131299491> Author: 最最遥远的路 · Zhihu profile: <https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>

本文原发表于知乎专栏/回答（中文）：<https://zhuanlan.zhihu.com/p/2082412798131299491>；作者：最最遥远的路：<https://www.zhihu.com/people/zui-zui-yao-yuan-de-lu-32/posts>